



Mostly sunny, windy 55/32 • Tomorrow: Sunny 50/40 B6

Democracy Dies in Darkness

WEDNESDAY, JANUARY 29, 2025 • \$4

Sweeping offer would cut federal workforce

White House email says employees who resign will be paid until Sept. 30

BY EMILY DAVIES, JEFF STEIN AND FAIZ SIDDIQUI

The White House's Office of Personnel Management sent an email blast Tuesday to federal employees offering them a way to resign with pay through Sept. 30, the most sweeping effort yet by the new Trump administration to shrink the ranks of the federal workforce.

The email instructed workers to reply to the message if they want to resign and take the offer, which expires Feb. 6. According to a White House Q&A, most of the 2.3 million federal workers are eligible for the incentive, which landed as many employees were facing return-to-office mandates and threats of layoffs.

"At this time, we cannot give you full assurance regarding the certainty of your position or agency, but should your position be eliminated you will be treated with dignity and will be afforded the protections in place for such positions," reads the email, which was titled "Fork in the Road."

The email blast came less than a day after the White House announced a freeze on federal spending that sent public officials scrambling for answers, with food safety, crime prevention and housing assistance programs, among others, on the line. And it topped off days of escalating anxiety over the personnel management office's deployment of a "new distribution system" that sent "test" **SEE EMAIL ON A14**

RFK Jr. repeatedly disparaged vaccines

HHS nominee publicly spread baseless fears and claims, Post review finds

BY LAUREN WEBER AND CAITLIN GILBERT

Robert F. Kennedy Jr., President Donald Trump's nominee for the nation's top health post, has repeatedly disparaged vaccines, falsely linked them to autism and argued that White and Black people should have separate vaccination schedules, according to a Washington Post review of his public statements from recent years.

In at least 36 appearances, Kennedy linked autism to vaccines, despite overwhelming scientific evidence supporting the use of vaccination to protect people from deadly infectious diseases and refuting any ties to autism, The Post found in a review of more than 400 of Kennedy's podcast appearances, interviews and public speeches since 2020.

SEE RFK JR. ON A4

Warning letter: Caroline Kennedy calls her cousin a "predator." **A5**

Border role: Former critic of Trump policy could help enforce it. **A6**

Fleeing new fighting in eastern Congo



TONY KARUMBA/AFP/GETTY IMAGES

Refugees fleeing violence in the Democratic Republic of Congo's east arrive in Rwanda. M23 rebels seized the city of Goma on Monday and took the city's airport Tuesday, imperiling a key route for humanitarian aid. The flare-up is one of the worst in a long conflict rooted in Rwanda's genocide and a fight for Congolese minerals. **Digest, A10**

MIT iconoclast shaped Gabbard's Syria views

Intelligence pick rejected U.S. assessments about chemical weapon attacks

BY ISAAC STANLEY-BECKER

The email came from an aide to Tulsi Gabbard specializing in military affairs. "Conversation Request," read the subject line of the October 2017 inquiry to a physicist at the Massachusetts Institute of Technology.

The Gabbard aide wanted to discuss events in Khan Sheikhoun, a rebel-held village in northern Syria and a flash point

in the country's long-running civil war. Days earlier, a United Nations investigative panel had concluded that the Syrian government was responsible for deploying chemical weapons against its own population there, echoing the findings of U.S. and French intelligence agencies about the April 2017 attack that killed an estimated 90 people, including dozens of children.

But Gabbard, then a Democratic congresswoman from Hawaii, was interested in an alternative explanation. So her aide sought the perspective of an iconoclastic MIT professor, Theodore A. Pos-



Tulsi Gabbard

tol, who in the months after the attack had released preliminary research suggesting that the use of chemical weapons in Syria had been staged by opposition forces.

The 2017 outreach, recorded in emails that Postol shared with The Washington Post, marked the beginning of his years-long engagement with Gabbard. The interactions, which included in-person and virtual briefings, help explain her contrarian views of atrocities in **SEE GABBARD ON A11**

Views on privacy: Gabbard has softened her strong stance. **A3**



OKSANA PARAFENIUK FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

U.S. foreign aid cuts vex Ukrainians

For nearly three years, distressed Ukrainian troops, veterans and their families — including some soldiers on the brink of suicide — have relied on a U.S.-funded hotline to connect with trained psychological, legal and medical experts.

But after President Donald Trump signed an executive order last week suspending almost all U.S. foreign aid programs for 90 days, the line went dark.

Move raises questions about future of support

BY SIOBHÁN O'GRADY AND SERHII KOROLCHUK IN KYIV

Ivona Kostyna is a co-founder of Ukraine's Veteran Hub, which had to abruptly close a hotline after it lost funding.

"The support line is temporarily unavailable," a recorded voice now tells callers. "The Veteran Hub thanks you for your trust. The consultants will return to work as soon as it becomes possible."

The Trump administration's sudden move to suspend foreign aid has thrust many countries into uncertainty as they assess how to proceed without the funding that has kept key social programs running **SEE UKRAINE ON A12**

What happened on Tuesday

President Donald Trump signed an executive order targeting federal support of gender-affirming care for children under age 19.

Trump moved to fire two Democratic members of the Equal Employment Opportunity Commission and the chair of the National Labor Relations Board.

The White House's Office of Personnel Management sent an email to civilian government employees offering them a way to resign with pay through Sept. 30.

U.S. Immigration and Customs Enforcement agents fanned out across New York City in a large immigration operation, resulting in about 20 arrests. **A6**

Area officials' concern grows over federal funds

Questions surround health care, disaster relief and other issues

BY GREGORY S. SCHNEIDER, MEAGAN FLYNN AND ERIN COX

State and local officials across the Washington area scrambled Tuesday to understand President Donald Trump's freeze of federal grants, which appeared to disrupt a wide swath of programs — from economic development to health care to disaster relief — despite the administration's assurances otherwise and even after a federal judge temporarily suspended it.

D.C. and Maryland joined 21 states in suing the Trump administration over the halt on grants late Tuesday, after a separate lawsuit from nonprofit groups led to the judge blocking the plan until Monday. But the actions did little to soothe the sense of confusion that hit hard in this government-dependent region.

"The Administration's sweeping order and subsequent attempts to clarify have sown immense chaos and confusion, caus-

Trump order leads to bedlam

UNWIELDY SPENDING FREEZE IS BLOCKED

Medicaid, education, housing funds imperiled

BY TONY ROMM, JEFF STEIN, JACOB BOGAGE AND EMILY DAVIES

A federal judge on Tuesday temporarily blocked President Donald Trump from imposing a sweeping pause on trillions of dollars in federal spending, capping a frenetic day of disruption to government programs that fund schools, provide housing and ensure low-income Americans have access to health care.

The order prevented the new restrictions from taking effect until at least Feb. 3, buying time for a coalition of public health advocates, nonprofits and businesses — represented by the left-leaning group Democracy Forward — to proceed with a case that may test Trump's claims of expansive power over the nation's fiscal trajectory.

The decision arrived amid a wave of chaos and confusion in Washington, where few appeared to understand the scope and intention of a White House memo that had directed agencies to "temporarily pause" the disbursement of key federal funds. Even before it could officially take effect at 5 p.m., thousands of government services — many dedicated primarily to Americans' health, safety and well-being — appeared to be at risk of interruption or shutdown, at least temporarily.

For hours, states reported issues accessing funds under Medicaid, even though the White **SEE SPENDING ON A7**

Shut off: States report problems accessing Medicaid dollars. **A7**

IN THE NEWS

Scrutiny for Milley Defense Secretary Pete Hegseth plans to remove the security detail from the longtime foe of Donald Trump and launch an inspector general investigation. **A14**

Reducing distractions Public schools in the District could ban cellphone use during the school day if a new bill is passed. **B1**

THE NATION The "Nation's Report Card" shows U.S. students lost more ground, especially in reading. **A3** **Officials identified** a new strain of avian influenza for the first time in the United States. **A4**

THE WORLD Once dying out, the ancient art of stilt walking has become a surprise trend in China. **A8** **Chinese start-up** DeepSeek has disrupted American plans for AI dominance. **A10**

THE ECONOMY Trump's tariffs plan would make shoe manufacturing more expensive but won't hit all brands equally. **A13** **Commerce secretary** nominee Howard Lutnick says he wants more U.S. factories, but one of his firms touts manufacturing in Mexico. **A14**

THE REGION An attorney for Traylor White Sr. offered the D.C. Council member's first extended response to the body's looming expulsion of him. **B1** **Myron Johnson**, 14, who was killed Sunday in Southwest, was the eldest of four siblings who enjoyed sports. **B1**

STYLE For years, artists have been painting Los Angeles on fire. Now their works look more and more like reality. **C1**

FOOD If you're the reluctant cook in your relationship, you can still find ways to contribute in the kitchen. **E1**

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